

Data Sources — Master Evidence Packet (Block Format)

This packet documents the official, public, verifiable data sources used throughout the project. Every dataset comes from a federal agency, and each entry explains what it measures, why it was selected, how it is updated, and where it can be independently checked.

DS1 — Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)

Consumer Price Index (CPI-U)

Series code: CPIAUCSL

What it measures: Inflation for all urban consumers.

Why used: Represents headline inflation and overall cost of living.

Update frequency: Monthly, seasonally adjusted.

Verify: <https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/CPIAUCSL>

CPI for Wage Earners (CPI-W)

Series code: CPIW

What it measures: Inflation for wage-earner households.

Why used: Used for Social Security COLA and comparison to CPI-U.

Update frequency: Monthly.

Verify: <https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/CPIW>

Average Hourly Earnings (All Employees)

Series code: CES0500000003

What it measures: Average hourly pay for private-sector workers.

Why used: Used to compare wage growth to inflation.

Update frequency: Monthly, seasonally adjusted.

Verify: <https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/CES0500000003>

Fed Balance Sheet — Total Assets

Series code: WALCL

What it measures: Total assets held by the Federal Reserve.

Why used: Shows the scale of quantitative easing and tightening.

Update frequency: Weekly.

Verify: <https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/WALCL>

Debt Service Ratio — Total

Series code: TDSP

What it measures: Percent of disposable income required for debt payments.

Why used: Indicates overall household debt burden.

Update frequency: Quarterly.

Verify: <https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/TDSP>

DS2 — U.S. Census Bureau Data

ACS 5-Year — Median Household Income

Table code: B19013

What it measures: Median household income for any selected area.

Why used: Sets the baseline for affordability analysis.

Update frequency: Annual (5-year pooled).

Verify: <https://data.census.gov/table?q=B19013>

ACS 5-Year — Gross Rent as % of Income

Table code: B25070

What it measures: Share of income households spend on rent.

Why used: Primary source for rent-burden statistics.

Update frequency: Annual.

Verify: <https://data.census.gov/table?q=B25070>

ACS 5-Year — Median Home Value

Table code: B25077

What it measures: Median value of owner-occupied homes.

Why used: Tracks housing cost trends.

Update frequency: Annual.

Verify: <https://data.census.gov/table?q=B25077>

DS3 — Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS)

CPI-U (All Items)

Series code: CUUR0000SA0

What it measures: Inflation for all items for urban consumers.

Why used: Standard headline inflation.

Update frequency: Monthly.

Verify: <https://data.bls.gov/cgi-bin/surveymost?bls>

Owner's Equivalent Rent (OER)

Series code: CUSR0000SEQ002

What it measures: Estimated rent homeowners would pay.

Why used: Largest component of CPI; crucial to housing inflation.

Update frequency: Monthly.

Verify: <https://data.bls.gov/cgi-bin/surveymost?bls>

Unemployment Rate (U-3)

Series code: LNS14000000

What it measures: Official unemployment rate.

Why used: Basic labor market condition.

Update frequency: Monthly.

Verify: <https://data.bls.gov/cgi-bin/surveymost?bls>

DS4 — CBO and GAO Reports

CBO — Budget and Economic Outlook

Year: 2024

What it covers: 10-year projections of spending, revenues, and deficits.

Why used: Baseline fiscal projections required for APA argumentation.

Verify: <https://www.cbo.gov/publication/59710>

GAO — Federal Financial Statements Audit

Year: 2024

What it covers: Audit of federal accounting systems and controls.

Why used: Documents inability to produce auditable books.

Verify: <https://www.gao.gov/products/gao-24-106660>

DS5 — HUD and FHFA Housing Data

Fair Market Rents (FMR)

Agency: HUD

What it measures: 40th-percentile rents for each county.

Why used: Determines value of housing vouchers; baseline rent cost.

Update frequency: Annual.

Verify: <https://www.huduser.gov/portal/datasets/fmr.html>

FHFA — Purchase-Only House Price Index

Agency: FHFA

What it measures: Home price appreciation based on sales only.

Why used: Removes refinance distortions.

Update frequency: Quarterly.

Verify: <https://www.fhfa.gov/DataTools/Downloads/Pages/House-Price-Index.aspx>

DS6 — Transparency & Methods Overview

All data in this project comes from official federal agencies including FRED, BLS, Census, HUD, FHFA, CBO, and GAO. No private vendors or scraped sources are used.

Inflation adjustments use CPI-U or related indexes to convert nominal values into constant dollars. When comparing values with different units, data was indexed to a common base year to show relative change instead of absolute levels.

To independently recreate any chart, a reader can paste the series code or table code into the corresponding federal website (FRED or data.census.gov). Each source in this packet includes a verification link for transparency.